

Tuesday

PRIORITY

- 09.00 • The cheese could have been stolen by the maid, who cleverly left a few crumbs to make it look like the handiwork of a mouse; and the scratching noises could have been caused by the boiler overheating.
- 10.00 • The given inference is clearly a reasonable one. For the hypothesis that a mouse ate the cheese seems to provide a better explanation of the data than the 'maid and boiler' hypothesis.
- 11.00 • After all, maids do not normally steal cheese, and modern boilers rarely overheat. Whereas mice do eat cheese when they get the chance, and do make scratching sounds. So although we cannot be certain that the mouse hypothesis is true, on balance it looks plausible.
- 12.00 • Reasoning of this sort is known as 'inference to the best explanation' or IBE for short.
- 13.00 • Scientists frequently use IBE. For example, Darwin argued for his theory of evolution by calling attention to various facts about the living world which are hard to explain if we assume that current species have been separately created, but which make perfect sense if current species have descended from common ancestors, as his theory held. For example, there are close anatomical similarities between the legs of horses and zebras. How do we explain this, if God created horses and zebras separately? Presumably he could have made their legs as different as he pleased. But if horses and zebras have descended from a common ancestor, this provides an obvious explanation of their anatomical similarity.

• Darwin argued that the ability of his theory to explain such facts constituted strong evidence for its truth. 'It can hardly be supposed', he wrote,

January 2024							February 2024						
Mo	Tu	We	Th	Fr	Sa	Su	Mo	Tu	We	Th	Fr	Sa	Su
01	1	2	3	4	5	6	05			1	2	3	4
02	8	9	10	11	12	13	06	5	6	7	8	9	10
03	15	16	17	18	19	20	07	12	13	14	15	16	17
04	22	23	24	25	26	27	08	19	20	21	22	23	24
05	29	30	31				09	26	27	28	29		